

Sita and Hanuman, to name just a few. Moreover, Ravi Varma's penchant for the dramatic pageant influenced popular theatre and films, thereby increasing the impact of his artifice exponentially.

In the latter half of the 19th century, the medium of oil-on-canvas itself was new to India and Ravi Varma's chosen style of painting—European realism (though outmoded in Europe by then)—was still unfamiliar and novel here. But once Ravi Varma had mastered both his technique and his style around the 1870s, there was no stopping him. His familial links with the Travancore ruling family ensured a network of connections that led to a spate of commissions ranging from tiny states like Pudukottai, Aundh and Bhavnagar to big guns like Mysore, Baroda and Hyderabad. He was much sought after not only for his portraits but also for his “thematic” paintings depicting pivotal scenes from Hindu myths and Sanskrit literature.

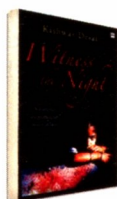
Paradoxically in contrast to his immense mass appeal and popular influence as India's first painter of iconic images, the life and legacy of Ravi Varma had never been seriously studied till now. Coming armed with awe-inspiring research and studded with gem-like details, *Raja Ravi Varma: Painter of Colonial India* is surely a long overdue opus. Yet, Rupika Chawla's lavishly produced book is not a heavy academic tome. In style and substance, it is hugely engaging, carrying its scholarship with a remarkable lightness of grace. Chawla's chronicling of Ravi Varma's life and works is detailed with a host of original archival material in the form of personal notes and letters, newspaper clippings, period photographs, court records, et al. Add to this rich array many illuminating anecdotes and contexts from secondary sources such as accounts of his patrons, colleagues and friends, the most important among these being the diaries kept by his beloved brother C. Raja Raja Varma, who was his pupil and partner in virtually all of the commissions and enterprises that Ravi Varma undertook.

The book brings alive the times and travails of this highly driven Indian artist who was the first to displace the monopoly of the itinerant (and minor) European painters who came here to paint coronation scenes and portraits of the native princes and the newly emerging Indian elite comprising of Indian civil servants and a few westernised businessmen. However, this book is not merely a biography of the celebrated painter. There have been a few of those already. What makes this endeavour significantly different is that it encompasses in its wide sweep swathes of social, cultural and political life in colonial India—especially that of the native princes—and it attempts to underline the newly emerging dynamic between technology and a colonised society bound by moribund feudal values that was aspiring to modernity, freedom and democracy. So the “shortening of time and distances” by the coming of the railways, the place of art “in the time of mechanical reproduction” and the double-edged politics of cultural nationalism all come into focus in this absorbing narrative of a painterly transience. ■

Areas of Darkness

The writing may be ordinary but this first novel has a strong moral message

By Brinda Bose



WITNESS THE NIGHT
by KISHWAR DESAI
HarperCollins
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There can be no faulting the ingredients thrown together for making a success out of *Witness the Night*, Kishwar Desai's first work of fiction about the horror of being born female in small-town north India, and they all work as effectively as they are meant to. We learn from the author's note that though the characters and places of her novel are entirely fictional, the events are derived from true cases of gender discrimination that are rampant in the country, knowledge about which

she has gathered first-hand from her father who was “possibly one of the very few incorruptible police officers who was posted in north India”.

The most significant achievement of the novel is that it revisits some of the darkest areas of our country's moral being, tells us tales such as we skim over every day in our morning newspapers, and pulls us up short in the absolute irony of its conception—that we need fiction to wave itself like a red flag before our jaded eyes before we can wake up again to the terrors that lurk continually in the truths that our daily lives are wrapped in.

Witness the Night chronicles the story of Durga, a 14-year-old girl who is found raped and mauled in a sprawling bungalow in Jullundur, Punjab, and who is mute and resistant in the face of the charge that she murdered 13 members of her family in that house despite being discovered there when the mayhem ended as its sole survivor, in a state of utter despair and disrepair. It is chronicled by a 45-year-old “NGO-type” social worker Simran, who is asked to intervene in the case when the police find it impossible to get Durga to talk, and who finds herself drawn inexorably to the silent adolescent whose untold story clearly reeks of misery and exploitation and the slow, steady annihilation of the kind of innocence one assumes is endemic to childhood—and this even before she could begin to enjoy being a child.

It is a harsh, dark tragedy with a final sliver of promise—and perhaps needed to be told as it has been by Desai, with the minimum of fuss and the maximum effect of verite. It does not matter that the telling is neither extraordinary nor exemplary. The message, in this case, is the medium. ■